Hans Zhu

Contact Information

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Citizenship: Australian

Research Interests Industrial Organisation, Health Economics (long-term care focus), Insurance Economics

Employment

Research Fellow, University of Melbourne, Oct 2026-
Melbourne Institute of Applied Economic and Social Research

Postdoctoral Researcher, National Association of Insurance Commissioners, Jul 2025-Oct 2026
Center for Insurance Policy and Research

Research Economist, (Australia) Productivity Commission 2017-2019

The Productivity Commission is the Australian Government's independent economic advisory which conducts research on public policy both at the request of government and through self-initiated research. In this role I conducted a wide range of econometric and descriptive analyses and wrote chapters of reports in the Productivity Commission's landmark inquiry on efficiency and competition in the Australian compulsory private pension fund market.

Education

Ph.D., Economics, Northwestern University 2025

Committee: Robert Porter (Co-chair), David Dranove (Co-chair), Gaston Illanes, Vivek Bhattacharya

M.A., Economics, Northwestern University 2020

B.A., Economics (Honours) w Diploma in Mathematical Sciences, University of Melbourne 2015

Working papers

"Limiting For-profit Provision in Nursing Home Markets" with Hyein Cho *(Submitted)*

Abstract: We examine whether policies that ban for-profit providers and allow for subsequent takeovers by not-for-profits can be effective at addressing quality shortfalls. We study the US nursing home industry, where quality provision has been a concern for many decades. We document a quality-access tradeoff that makes welfare effects theoretically ambiguous: not-for-profit providers choose higher-quality inputs than their for-profit counterparts but serve wealthier residents, leaving for-profit providers to play an important role in providing access. We estimate a structural model of nursing home demand and supply, revealing that while not-for-profit providers have substantial non-pecuniary motives, in equilibrium, not-for-profit providers target residents with stronger preferences for quality due to their cost disadvantage. Accordingly, not-for-profit takeovers of the lowest quality for-profit providers reduce consumer surplus by $2.3 million a year on average. These results underscore the role that for-profit providers play in expanding access to nursing home care.

"Reinsuring Private Credit by Private Equity" with Paul Kim

Abstract: Over the last decade, U.S. life insurers have aggressively shifted reserves to offshore jurisdictions while simultaneously reallocating portfolios toward private credit. This paper finds that the two are linked through private equity reinsurers domiciled in Bermuda. Insurers benefit directly or indirectly from exposure to higher yielding private credit and the more competitive reinsurance market. Private equity with a large presence in Bermuda can access desired blocks of life insurer capital for their private credit investments as a reinsurer. Using comprehensive regulatory filings from 2011-2024, we exploit the

staggered adoption of offshore reinsurance agreements, to estimate the causal impact of these arrangements on portfolio allocation. Two years following the execution of such a reinsurance agreement with a private-equity backed reinsurer, insurers increase their investments in NAIC 1 long-term bonds in private credit by 1.4 percentage points or a third of the median share of investments in private credit. In addition, these reinsurance and portfolio allocation decisions coincide with changes in the annuity product market. Two years following the execution of such a reinsurance agreement, insurers also increase their annual total annuity premiums (lump sum deposits) collected by around $0.82 billion.

"Could it be Better to Refund than Recommend? The Role of Ex-post Match Values in Digital Entertainment Markets"

Abstract: Digital entertainment markets are characterised by many niches and the 'long tail' of consumption. I argue that the size of these tails may be dramatically underestimated if ex-post match values - match values realised only after consumption - are not taken into account. I collect a novel individual-level dataset on the Steam platform and interpret playtime data as directly informative about ex-post match values. The playtime data reveal patterns of consumption starkly different to those inferred from purchases. I then examine the policy relevance of ex-post match values, by studying a unique series of policy changes on the Steam platform. The introduction of personalised stores followed by the introduction of refunds. Personalised stores should improve consumer matches on average, but are unable to recommend on the basis of realised ex-post match values. Refunds allow consumers to realise ex-post match values before committing to the purchase. I find that sales increase following the introduction of refunds by around 5 times the increase following the introduction of personalised stores. In addition, the sales patterns following the introduction of refunds are dramatically different compared to those with the introduction of personalised stores. These results suggest that the effects of personalised stores alone are limited. Whether personalised stores matter or are complementary to refunds will be investigated using a structural model which I describe.

Work in progress

"The Impacts of Vertical Integration of Home Health Agencies in Medicare Advantage" with Anqi Chen and Jun Li

"Regulated Pricing Across Health Systems" with Yuting Zhang

Fellowships & Awards

Dissertation University Fellowship, Northwestern University 2024–2025

Wilfred Prest Travelling Fellowship, University of Melbourne 2018–19

Teaching Experience

Teaching Assistant, Northwestern University

Introduction to Microeconomics	2020,2021,2022
Microeconomics I	2021,2022,2023 (x2),2024
Introduction to Applied Econometrics	2021
Economics of Medical Care	2023
Topics in Economic History: The Israel Economy	2022

Teaching Assistant, Kellogg School of Management

Technology and Innovation Strategy, Sarit Markovich	2022

Research Experience

Research Assistant, Molly Schnell, Northwestern University Summer 2020

Presentations and Conferences

University of Melbourne, ARIA 2026 2026

University of Western Australia, Inspector-General of Aged Care (Aus Govt), Southern Economic Association Annual Meeting 2025

University of Auckland, Productivity Commission (Aus Govt), The Treasury (Aus Govt) 2024

NBER Digitisation Tutotrial 2022

Service

Graduate Studies Committee 2021–2022

Languages

English (native), Mandarin (conversational)

References

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